

Turtle — Product & Strategy Overview

Build codename: Project Pandora | Pilot: Hyderabad launch

REVISED THIS UPDATE — In-app currency renamed from Zar to Coins (placeholder pending a final name). V0 build scope clarified and separated from the long-term vision; Activity Card engagement model added as the pilot's primary non-Quest engagement mechanic; Phase roadmap corrected to match actual V0 build order; build path and budget constraint documented.

1. Core Concept

Turtle rewards real-world movement, not just vacation travel. A hex-grid fog-of-war mechanic clears as a user physically explores — starting hyper-local with everyday movement and scaling naturally into vacation-scale travel using the same mechanic. Engagement is anchored by a Creator-authored quest economy and a 100-level progression system in the long-term design; the pilot build reaches this state in phases (see Section 7A).

2. Competitive Landscape

This is a validated, active category, not an empty market — Fog of World, Walksy, and Breevy all run comparable fog-reveal exploration mechanics today. None of the three currently run a Creator-authored quest economy of Turtle's shape, and none pay users back with anything beyond in-app status. Both gaps anchor Turtle's differentiation.

3. Base, Territory & Squad Model

Every user declares a Base — their home city or town — verified by physical presence rather than self-report, since an unverifiable path would undermine both the integrity of the system and the real-world density data that later business partnerships depend on. Re-declaration is always possible, always verified, and rate-limited.

Territory progress is tracked per user, never globally exclusive — every explorer builds their own progress against the same geography, with no ownership contest between users. Group exploration through a “Squad” is a trust-based, opt-in overlay on top of that individual progress, not a separately tracked shared record. Squads are not part of the V0 pilot build (see Section 7A).

4. Quest Model

Quests sit at the center of engagement in the long-term design. A small, vetted, background-checked Creator population authors location-based challenges across a growing set of themes (history, food, architecture, and more); a much larger Explorer population takes them. Verified genuine effort is rewarded even when a quest isn't completed successfully, so honest attempts are never worth nothing.

System-generated Meta Quests handle onboarding and milestone scoring without any Creator involved. A validated future direction extends the same quest framework to sponsored live events — concerts, conferences, exhibitions — turning a venue into its own explorable micro-map.

The Quest engine, and the Creator population that authors it, are deliberately not part of the V0 pilot build — see Section 4A for what actually drives engagement during the pilot instead.

4A. Activity Model (V0 pilot engagement, pre-Quest)

Since Quests require a Creator population the pilot doesn't have yet, V0 engagement runs on a self-generated mechanic instead: the Activity Card. An Explorer logs an Activity — a photo or voice-note capture, optionally grouped into a named session spanning a whole outing — which both boosts their own tile progress and gives them a personal, categorized record of what they've done.

Activities are deliberately framed as everyday exploration, not just landmark tourism — an ordinary spa visit, a night drive, or a market walk all count. This keeps the psychological positioning consistent with the long-term Quest model,

where the same ethos applies, while giving the pilot a working engagement loop months before a Creator population could realistically exist.

Eight categories anchor this for V0: Sightseeing & Heritage, Dining, Nature & Outdoors, Sports & Adventure, Events, Nightlife, Wellness, and Travel. Full subcategory detail lives in the Technical Design Spec. The category set is stored as admin-editable data, not hardcoded, so it can grow without a rebuild.

Once a real Creator population and Quest content exist post-pilot, Activities don't disappear — they become a natural pipeline for crowdsourced Quest candidates, and the categorization built for V0 carries forward rather than being replaced.

5. Reward Economy

Tourtlet runs two separate reward tracks in the long-term design, deliberately decoupled from each other. Explorers earn Coins, a non-transactable points currency usable only inside Tourtlet's own redemption catalog — structurally the same closed-loop model as an airline miles program, chosen specifically to avoid the legal complexity a transactable, peer-to-peer currency would carry.

Creators are compensated through a separate track entirely. Pre-revenue, this consists of status, recognition, early access, and real-world promotional exposure, plus a performance score tracked from day one toward a future revenue-sharing fund once the business reaches a stage where real partner revenue exists to share.

Coins, CreatorScore, and the redemption catalog are not part of V0. The pilot's incentive layer is visual progress (the map filling in as tiles Unlock), a streak counter, and a cohort leaderboard among pilot testers — see Section 7A.

6. Differentiation

- A genuine real-world redemption layer, once business partnerships launch — none of the three direct competitors currently pay users back beyond in-app status.
- Creator-authored quest content, gated by scarcity and background verification rather than open submission — a deliberately more moderation-resilient approach than fully open community-contribution models used elsewhere in the industry.
- Per-user, non-exclusive territory progression paired with a real-place naming layer, giving explorers identity and bragging rights without the legal and data complexity of using actual administrative boundaries as core game logic.

7. Phased Roadmap (long-term vision)

Phase	Focus	Gate to next phase
Pilot (Hyderabad)	iOS, free tier, core exploration loop, seeded quest content, Coins live, Creator scoring begins	Sustained engagement, real usage data
Phase 2	Open Creator applications, local business coupon marketplace, live Creator payouts begin	Demonstrated user density, proven trust systems
Phase 3	Android, additional cities, a private data tier, the live-event vertical, expanded top-tier rewards	Phase 2 retention and revenue proof points

Note: this table describes the long-term vision as originally scoped. Section 7A below reflects what the pilot build actually ships with, which is narrower — see that section for the accurate near-term sequencing.

7A. V0 Pilot Build — Actual Scope

The pilot does not launch with quest content, Coins, or Creator scoring active, contrary to the original Phase table above. It launches with a deliberately reduced scope, chosen so the core hypothesis — will people repeatedly move through the city to clear fog — can be tested cheaply before investing in the systems that depend on real usage telemetry to tune correctly.

In scope for V0

- Automatic hex-tile fog clearing via GPS movement (on foot or vehicle).
- Tile states limited to Unclaimed → Activated → Unlocked.
- Cumulative dwell-time progress toward Unlocked (pilot-launch guess: 10 minutes, server-configurable).
- Activity Cards (Section 4A) as an additional, faster path to Unlocked.
- Visual progress fill, streak counter, and a cohort leaderboard as the incentive layer.
- A deliberate, user-initiated permission upgrade to background location, with a persistent status indicator.

Explicitly deferred to post-pilot

- Quest system, Creator role and verification, CreatorScore, Coins economy.
- Squad layer.
- 100-level / six-tier progression and its XP curve constants.
- Activity Card editing, carousel presentation, sharing, and structured itinerary/cost/booking fields.

8. Business Model Notes

The app remains free to use throughout the pilot, funded through runway rather than user-side revenue. Local business partnerships — the intended long-term revenue driver — are deliberately sequenced after the pilot proves real user density, rather than launched simultaneously, based on the well-documented failure pattern of prior local-rewards startups that tried to build both sides of that marketplace at once.

8A. Build Path & Budget Constraint (V0)

The pilot is being built solo, without a hired developer or agency, using Flutter with AI-assisted development (Claude Code) as the primary build tool. iOS-native signing and App Store/TestFlight mechanics are being handled without outside help as well.

A hard budget gate exists on external pilot distribution: the Apple Developer Program (\$99/yr) is not yet funded. Build and solo device testing proceed at zero cost via free personal-team Xcode signing. There is no free path to distribute to other testers' devices — TestFlight and ad-hoc distribution both require the paid program — so the actual early-adopter pilot cannot begin until this is funded, even though the app itself can be built and validated solo before then.

9. Outstanding Items for Future Resolution

- Pre-revenue runway budgeting for the pilot phase.
- Creator Fund scaling policy and payout threshold once Phase 2 launches.
- Finalized XP and engagement curves, pending real pilot telemetry.
- Content moderation and review staffing plan.
- Live-event vertical build timeline, pending core pilot stabilization.
- Dwell-time threshold and Activity-boost constants — 10 minutes and flat-boost are pilot-launch guesses, to be tuned against real telemetry.
- Apple Developer Program enrollment funding — hard gate on external pilot distribution.